

Engineering Career Paths at Big Tech and Scaleups

Levels at big tech, the most common career paths, and what comes after making it to Staff.



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👋 Hi, this is [Gergely](#) with the Pragmatic Engineer Newsletter. In every issue, I cover challenges at big tech and high-growth startups through the lens of engineering managers and senior engineers.

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This issue focuses on engineering career paths at high-growth startups and big tech. I cover [questions sent by subscribers](#) around engineering career paths. We'll cover:

Engineering career paths:

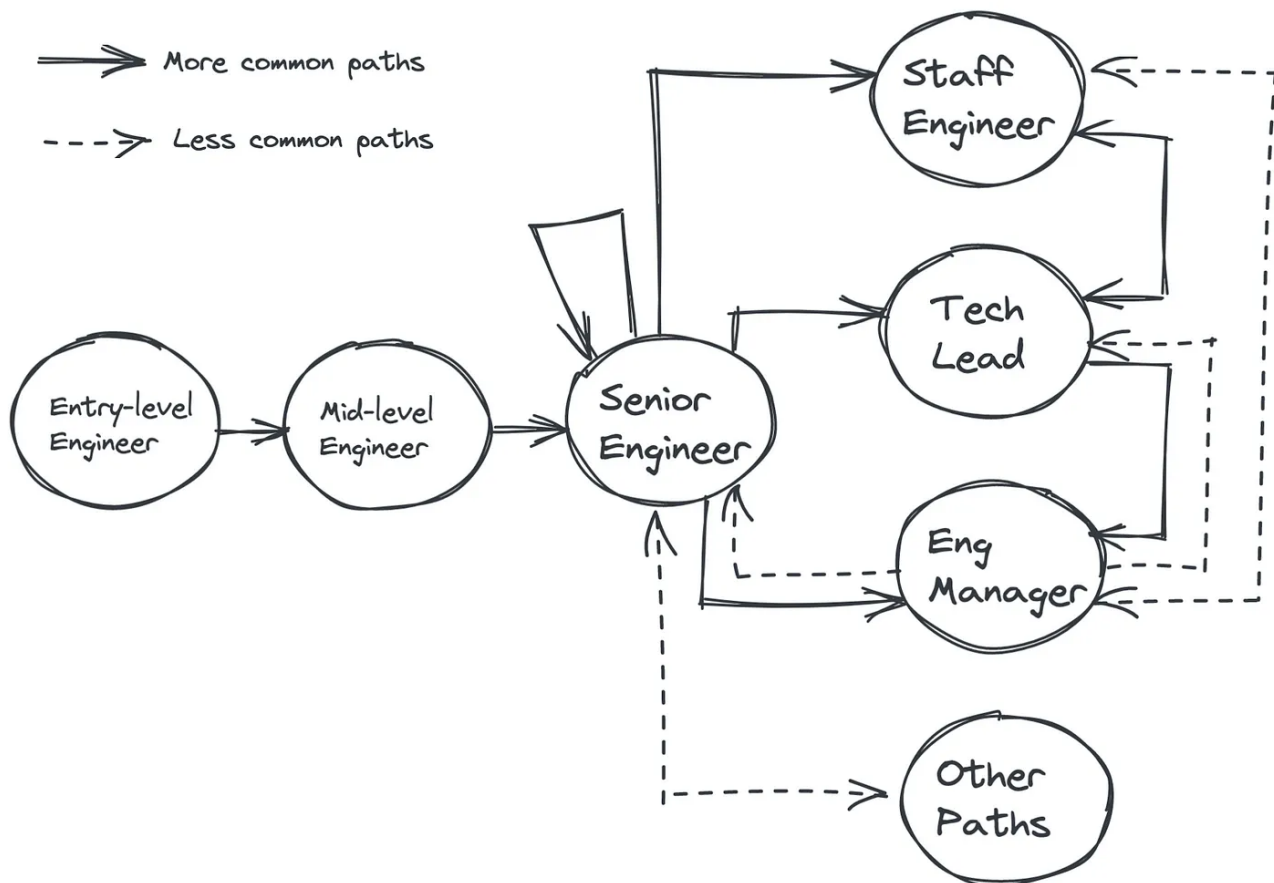
- Typical engineering career paths at big tech and the leveling system
- Career path differences between high-growth startups and big tech
- What next after hitting the Staff level at big tech?
- Not-so-typical engineering career paths

Advice for engineers and managers:

- Advice on how to think about your career, as an engineer
- Advice on how engineering managers can help engineers with their careers

Q: I recently joined a large tech company as an entry-level software engineer (they call it L3 here). What is a typical career path at these companies?

First and foremost: everyone's career path is different. I'll share career paths I've observed more commonly. Do keep in mind that everyone has different situations, team dynamics, and opportunities. Here are some of the most common career paths I've seen at large tech companies.



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Common - and less common - engineering career paths at big tech

The entry-level-to-senior path. An engineer joins at the entry-level position: either as a new grad or with a few years of experience, typically outside of big tech. After a few years, they get promoted to the next position - many companies call this Engineer 2 or a similar name. After another few years, they get promoted to Senior engineer. At this point, paths tend to diverge.

Staying a Senior Engineer - for a long time. The majority of engineers who make it to the Senior level at big tech tend to stay at this level for an extended period. This is by design. Senior engineers typically have a high level of responsibility and compensation that matches this. They are usually compensated at a similar level to what frontline managers earn at these companies.

Moving beyond the senior level is not just a matter of additional skills and opportunities, but it also means changing how you work. The positions above the senior engineer level tend to be very different from the software engineering role. Both staff engineers and managers are expected to be force multipliers or enablers. Taking this step "up" can take the joy out of their day-to-day work for many engineers.

You can have a great career staying at the senior software engineer level, especially if you love being hands-on and working with small teams. Some engineers move around, learning different tech stacks. For example, a backend engineer might move over to the mobile team, picking up this technology, and a few years later, might move over to ML engineering. The nice thing about big tech is how moving stacks is encouraged, and it does not result in title or compensation changes. I took advantage of this flexibility throughout my career.

Moving stacks makes you a more rounded engineer. A new stack helps learn more and can make the job more fun than before. Becoming hands-on with multiple stacks can also serve as a solid base for later in your career, as it makes it easier to work across various teams. Working across teams and stacks can later help grow into tech lead or staff engineer roles.

Going up a level typically means more responsibilities and more stress - and, counterintuitively, it might not mean more compensation in all cases. Compensation might not change significantly a level up for senior engineers who have received large

equity grants. This is especially true if the equity value has grown significantly and accounts for most of their total compensation.

The current [hot tech hiring market for senior engineers](#) showcases how compensation at the staff/principal roles are not necessarily that much higher than at the senior engineering positions. Several Staff engineers job hunting shared that Staff and Principal packages have increased less, and senior compensation went up more, especially outside of big tech.

The Senior Engineer to Staff/Principal Engineer path. The Staff and Principal levels are fundamentally different from senior engineering levels. Most Senior+ roles expect a longer-term, more strategic outlook, where influencing people, leading larger initiatives, and more frequent context switches are a given. Enabling others or being a technical coordinator across a complex domain is often expected. There are a few cases where going very deeply technical is the expectation.

While a senior engineer typically works across a team, a Staff or Principal engineer usually works across a larger organization. CTO Will Larson collected [four distinct Staff engineer archetypes](#) that most Senior+ roles fall into.

Engineers who like being hands-on, don't like context switching and like to see immediate results of their work might not enjoy Staff or Principal-level positions. Those who look for these challenges will often expand their impact and influence across teams and the organization. With support from their manager chain, peers, and some luck, they get promoted to the Staff engineer level.

Promotions to Staff within the company are more challenging than they are up to the Senior level. Up to the Senior level, expectations are usually clear, as are promotion paths. Beyond Senior, there is a lot more ambiguity on what output and behaviors are expected to get to the next level. Getting this internal promotion often takes more than one cycle, and it is especially challenging if you're not getting actionable feedback or don't have a strong network within the organization.

Another common way to get to this Staff level at big tech is to work for a few years as a senior engineer at another big tech company, then interview at other companies. With

luck, you might be able to get a Staff offer, getting to this level a bit faster than getting promoted from within. This move is especially common when a senior engineer feels they have few options to get to the Staff level at their current organization.

Finally, going from Big Tech to a late-stage but highly growing company - like a Series D or E one - is another common way to go from Senior to Staff-levels. At these companies, there are plenty of opportunities for Staff-level work. There are also typically fewer Staff-level candidates applying, and it can be easier to negotiate a Staff title tied with a good interview performance or strong references.

The Senior Engineer to Tech Lead path. After working at a senior engineer level, some people start to take on more tech and project lead responsibilities, but without being responsible for all people management aspects for people on their team.

At certain companies, there might be a level after Senior Engineer called Tech Lead, Squad Lead, or Tech Lead Manager. These positions still expect engineers to code, but expand responsibilities with ensuring that their team performs well. These teams are usually small, up to around 5 engineers. Performance management for directs is usually not part of responsibilities, but hiring almost always is. They are often a good window of the engineering manager career path.

The Senior Engineer to Engineering Manager path. Senior engineers who are already doing tech lead-like activities sometimes have the opportunity to move into engineering management at teams that are growing quickly. This was how I also transitioned into management at Uber.

Many larger tech companies have training programs in place for first-time engineering managers. The transition at these places usually includes a safe way back into software engineering if the manager path just doesn't work out well. Better companies realize that they need to both support new managers and also provide a safe way back into engineering for people who turn out to be better engineers than managers.

Most smaller companies don't offer any training and very have little support for first-time engineering managers. However, at these places, the opportunities to move into

management are more plentiful. If you work at such a place: know that you'll be left to your own devices if you take the manager route.

Engineering managers typically code very little, if any, at big tech. Instead, they manage teams of 6-12 people, spend lots of their time between hiring activities, ensuring the team is healthy, helping team members grow, and making sure their team works on the right things. They are responsible both for performance management and promotions on the team and tend to be involved with most of the team's stakeholders: both with other engineering managers, product managers, data science, and other functions.

Bouncing between big tech companies. Once someone makes it into big tech as a software engineer, it becomes easier to switch between companies. Passing the resume screen is a lot easier, and the interview process is likely almost identical to the one at their current company.

Moving between big tech can mean increasing compensation significantly with each move, even when staying at the same level. With the current, very hot market that is up 15-30% the past year, switching companies is often the fastest way to get paid market-level packages.

Leveling between more mature companies is starting to become more standardized. While getting a financial bump is common, getting a title bump is harder to do when joining a company similar in size and in maturity.

I have nothing against moving companies - as it could be the right call for many people. The only suggestion I have is to consider the learnings that come with tenure - staying for years at the same company. Read more on advice on changing companies or staying for a promotion in the newsletter issue [Preparing for promotions ahead of time.](#)

Q: What do things like L3 or E6 at various tech companies mean?

We cannot talk about big tech careers without mentioning engineering levels. Every large tech company has put career ladders in place for individual contributors and managers. They all use internal naming and numbering to refer to each of these levels.

It's hard to compare levels between any two companies, as expectations and responsibilities tend to be defined differently. For example, the Senior Engineer level can mean far more responsibilities and skill expectations at Google than it does at a small startup.

The website [Levels.fyi](https://levels.fyi) visualizes levels at most larger companies and attempts to draw how these levels compare to each other. They answer the question “what level would I transfer into if I were switching companies?” using leveling rubrics, mapping similar scopes and responsibilities based on the information they gathered:

Apple	Uber	Google	Facebook	Microsoft
ICT2 Junior Software Engineer	Software Engineer I 3	L3 SWE II	E3	SDE 59
ICT3 Software Engineer	Software Engineer II 4	L4 SWE III	E4	60
ICT4 Senior Software Engineer	Senior Software Engineer 5a	L5 Senior SWE	E5	SDE II 61
ICT5	Senior Software Engineer II 5b	L6 Staff SWE	E6	62
ICT6	Staff Software Engineer 6	L7 Senior Staff SWE	E7	Senior SDE 63
Distinguished Engineer	Senior Staff Software Engineer 7	L8 Principal Engineer	E8	64
Senior Distinguished Engineer	Principal Engineer	L9 Distinguished Engineer	E9	Principal SDE 65
Engineering Fellow		L10 Google Fellow		66
				67
				Partner 68
				69
				70
				Distinguished Engineer 80
				Technical Fellow

Engineering levels comparison on [Levels.fyi](https://levels.fyi). A good source to get a sense on how levels at various companies could map to one another, based on the scope of work and expectations.

I'm working on a series that covers leveling at larger tech companies - if you are open to sharing expectations at your company - either on or off the record - please do hit reply.

The [Radford Global Scale](https://www.radfordglobal.com/radford-global-scale) is another approach to defining levels internally:

Sample Career Ladders within a Global Job Leveling System

Business Leadership	Executive	Management	7	Vice President					
	Grade 11		6	Sr. Director					
	Grade 10		5	Director	Professional	6	Principal		
Management and Professional	Grade 9		4	Sr. Manager		5	Expert		
	Grade 8		3	Manager		4	Advanced		
	Grade 7		2	Sr. Supervisor		3	Career		
	Grade 6		1	Supervisor		2	Developing	Support	5
Entry Level and Support	Grade 5				1	Entry	4		Highly Skilled
	Grade 4						3		Senior
	Grade 3						2		Intermediate
	Grade 2						1		Entry

A sample career ladder using the Radford Global Scale: defining a Manager, Professional and Support track. Software engineers are typically on the Professional, while engineering managers are on the Manager tracks.

Microsoft was one of the earliest companies to standardize their levels internally. They have an unusual numbering and approach in how new grads start at L59, and they map two or more levels to each external title:

Title	Levels	Radford Global Scale (approximation)
Software Development Engineer	59, 60	Entry (P1)
Software Engineer 2	61, 62	Developing (P2)
Senior Software Engineer	63, 64	Career (P3)
Principal Software Engineer	65, 66, 67	Advanced (P4)
Partner Software Engineer	68, 69, 70	Expert (P5)
Distinguished Engineer	71	Principal (P6)

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Google is the company that influenced many other big tech companies in their leveling. Companies that follow a similar internal leveling include Uber, Databricks, Airbnb, Instacart, Asana and others.

Level	Title (Google)	Title (Uber)	Databricks	Radford Global Scale (approximation)
L3	SWE (Software Engineer)	Software Engineer	Software Engineer	Entry (P1)
L4	SWE 2	Software Engineer 2	Software Engineer 2	Developing (P2)
L5	SWE 3 (Senior Software Engineer)	Senior Software Engineer (Split into two levels: L5A and L5B)	Senior Software Engineer	Career (P3)
L6	Staff SWE	Staff Software Engineer	Staff Software Engineer	Advanced (P4)
L7	Senior Staff SWE	Senior Staff Software Engineer	Senior Staff Software Engineer	Expert (P5)
L8	Principal SWE	Principal Software Engineer	Principal Software Engineer	Principal (P6)

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Facebook follows the same leveling as Google, except they prefix engineering levels with an "E", and have levels from E3 to E10. They don't have public titles for each level: engineer has the same title of Software Engineer. They do this for Product Managers as

well. This makes it tricky to figure out how experienced someone with a Software Engineer title might be at Facebook: they could be from an entry-level engineer to one of the very few E9, senior principal engineers.

Netflix is a standout on how they have one single level: Senior Software Engineer. They pay every person differently, based on their market value, and are one of the only companies that keep up with the market. They are known not to shy away from increasing compensation by the amount that the market has gone up.

Other interesting leveling approaches include :

- *Amazon*, where the entry-level engineering level [is called L4](#).
- *Apple*, which [starts leveling](#) from ICT2.
- *Bytedance*, which [has four levels](#), each split in two with a dash.

Q: What are the differences in career paths between high-growth startups and big tech?

High-growth startups are places where both the business and the engineering team grow very quickly.

Growing in seniority as the company grows is a career path these environments open up. When joining either early enough or at the beginning of the next growth stage, engineers often find themselves building systems that impact all of the business or in charge of a small engineering team.

At big tech, it's almost impossible to get promoted in less than two years to the next level. However, at high-growth companies, some engineers might go from software engineer to Staff or principal levels in a few years, promoted almost every year. As long as there is plenty of room to make an impact, career growth speed is almost always above that of big tech.

Career growth options are less clear, and career paths less mature. Startups usually have less experienced leaders, and those leaders are usually busy putting out

the next fire. It's less common to see those leaders work ahead on things like career paths or growth plans.

High-growth environments sometimes also don't do justice in showcasing this growth through titles. A startup focusing on growing 60% year-over-year might not pay much attention to career leveling or defining titles. This might lead to people with significant career growth being rewarded within the organization, but this growth not reflected through external-facing titles.

Startups carry a lot more risk as well: the growth of the business could halt any time, and the company might have to make drastic changes if this happens. Startups usually have less capital and typically pay lower cash compensation than what most of big tech have to offer. However, with the current startup investor market, some well-funded startups match big tech base salaries. At better startups, equity makes up for the difference in cash compensation, though.

Moving into management is typically easier in startups, and opportunities to do so tend to be plenty with high-growth companies. In larger companies, experienced engineers often struggle to find opportunities that can accelerate their learning and career.

Keep in mind that the difference between engineers and managers is often less clear within startups. This can be great, as you can easily pick up managerial responsibilities and get a feel for this work. It can be frustrating if you're used to clearly defined roles and responsibilities, which rarely happen in small places.

Many Director of Engineering or Head of Engineering positions at Series A or Series B-stage startups are former senior engineers who worked their way up to this position. This engineer typically first led a smaller team, then was promoted to oversee more of engineering. This kind of experience often significantly accelerates their career.

Keep in mind that [down-leveling can be common](#) when moving to a larger company from a startup.

Q: I've hit the Staff level at Big Tech and I'm unsure what next. What advice do you have?

First of all, congratulations! Many engineers don't make it to the Staff level, despite wanting to reach this point badly. Take some time to celebrate, and then some more to get good at the role. You're surrounded by competent folks, and meeting expectations can be a challenge if you're not up to speed yet.

Realize this might be your terminal level as an individual contributor at big tech, and you might not find opportunities to grow to the next level. The more mature the company is and the fewer rapidly growing organizations there are, the more likely this is the case. Even if you would target the next level, it will likely take years to make a case for promotion.

Do a stint in management if you've not had this experience before. Even if management isn't your long-term career, you'll gain lots of perspective being a manager. As a Staff or above engineer, you need to be a true partner to managers, and this is much easier once you've done their job.

Being a manager at some point in your career gives you credibility to lead later on and opens several options down the line. You could move to a smaller company to be their CTO or VP of Engineering. You can start as a Chief Architect and transition to the Head of Engineering role. If you start your own company, you'll have hands-on experience hiring and motivating engineers. If you go into consulting, you'll work more efficiently with decision-makers.

Going back from a manager to an engineer used to be rare in the past, but it's more common to do so: especially at big tech. As Honeycomb CTO Charity Majors writes in [The Engineer Manager Pendulum](#):

"Conversely: the best tech leads in the world are always the ones who have done time in management. (...) Senior engineers who have both these toolsets are the kind of tech leads you can build an org around, or a company around. They get shit done. And they are rare."

I second this point. The best Staff and above engineers I worked with all shared one characteristic: they took on engineering management at one point. Some were okay with it, and some did not like it. However, they all stuck with it for a year or two and came out as better engineers, with an understanding and empathy for management that books can't teach you.

Keep learning and separate your growth from chasing the next level. Get involved in various projects, get to know people across new teams and organizations.

Invest in your network both inside and outside the company. Make a conscious effort to get to know more people across engineering and non-engineering within the company. Reach out to interesting people within the industry, or make it easy for these people to find you.

Give back to the community externally. Write, do talks at conferences or mentor people outside the company. Writing is a great skill to invest in if you've not done so by this point - and don't only do your writing internal to the company. Giving back externally not only helps others in the industry and casts a positive light for your company, but it also [increases your luck surface area](#).

Take calculated risks when you notice opportunities to make a difference at the organizational or company level. There is no more "standard playbook" to follow if you'd like to grow further. You need to take bets on where the company or the industry will go, then execute on projects that will help your company or organization make the most of these future opportunities, or tackle those future threats.

Consider taking career risks by taking what might seem like a step down to a smaller but rapidly growing company where you can grow faster and take on more responsibility, over time, than what you could have achieved at your current place.

Take inspiration from engineers a few levels up. Talk or observe engineers at higher levels - like the principal or distinguished ones. What did they do to get there? What does their day-to-day work look like? Is this something you want to aim for, and is it something you can - or want - to attempt?

Q: What are less "typical" but successful career paths you've seen in the industry?

There are many paths into software engineering and engineering leadership, and every path is unique. To illustrate this, I'd like to share a few less common ones shared by people [on Twitter](#) or in my network:



Karthik Hariharan
@hkarthik

[@GergelyOrosz](#) Mine was atypical. QA Engineer -> Performance (JVM Tuning) -> consulting at a Big4 -> contract dev -> mid level eng at startups -> senior software eng to eng management at big tech.

4:11 PM · Oct 15, 2021

- **Non-technical background:** Non-tech role (e.g. customer service) → Learning to code on the side → Software engineer at the same company
- **From UX:** Graphic artist → Wordpress developer → Front-end architect
- **From bootcamp:** Coding bootcamp → Coding bootcamp instructor → Sr SWE at a Fortune 50 company
- **From academia:** Academia → Sr Data Scientist → Lead Software Engineer → Sr Software Engineer (Data Science)
- **From QA:** QA engineer → Performance engineer → Consulting at the Big 4 → Software engineer at startups → Engineering Manager, then Sr Engineering Manager at big tech
- **Founder:** Software Engineer → Sr Software Engineer → Staff Software Engineer → Startup founder
- **Into product management:** Software Engineer at big tech → Software Engineer 2 → Product Manager → Product Director
- **Into Technical Program Manager (TPM):** Software engineer → Senior Software Engineer at big tech → TPM → Sr TPM

- **Into and away from product:** Software Engineer → Product Director → Staff Engineer
- **To sales engineering:** Software Engineer → Senior Sw Engineer → Senior Sales Engineer

For senior engineers who look for job security but are jaded with coding day-to-day and don't want to move up the ladder is to move to a field where their technical background gives them an edge. These positions could be Product Management, Technical Program Management, Partnerships, or Sales Engineering. These people are often revitalized with new challenges and a new environment.

Advice on how to think about your career as an engineer

There is no shortage in the variety of career paths people have taken, both on the beaten track and off of it. There are many options to change teams, change companies, or even change fields. Here's advice I'll leave you with, as an engineer:

- **The industry is small**, and you start to experience this 5-10 years into your career. This is the point when you start to come across former colleagues more frequently. If you've made a great impression at the time, the same people might reach out with new and exciting opportunities. The more positive impressions you leave and the fewer bridges you burn, the more unexpected doors might open.
- **Getting to the senior engineer level is relatively straightforward.** Most people who spend 5-8 years in the industry get to the senior engineer level even if they make no focused effort to do so. Just by solving engineering problems for this long, you gain the experience, the toolset, and the perspective that most senior engineers need. You can speed this growth process up [with the right mentors](#) and at places where you get more support and feedback to grow.
- **It gets challenging after the senior engineering level.** Going from the senior engineering level to the next one - typically Tech Lead or Staff engineer - is usually a clear target. However, it's not nearly as easy to make that jump as getting to the senior level. And beyond these levels, there is no playbook you can use.

- **Consider becoming an engineering manager.** There is more demand and openings for engineering management in the industry than for staff and above engineers. At big tech, the engineering manager to engineer ratio tends to be 1:5-12, while the staff engineer to engineer ratio is more typically around 1:20-50. Not only can it be easier to switch to engineering management for a while, but once you go back to being an engineer, you'll have the skills and experience to grow faster on the individual contributor track.
- **Your manager becomes increasingly important later on in your career.** Most managers have reached the senior engineering levels themselves and know how to help others get there. However, many managers have not been promoted beyond this. If this is the case, they can struggle to help grow beyond this level. A manager who is on a growth path themselves and knows how to navigate the organization and influence others can help a fair bit with your growth: while a less experienced manager can significantly slow it down.
- **Joining highly regarded startups in their growth phase can strengthen your network** - by a lot. Your network is people who know you, and those who know of you, and might recommend you or reach out to you to work in their company. If you join a startup that attracts high-caliber people and grows fast, you'll get to directly work with many smart, driven, and entrepreneurial people. If the startup does very well - and you have [equity](#) - you'll also do very well. If the startup fails, all those smart and driven people will leave to other, even more promising places, and they'll often reach out for you to join them.
- **The more senior you become, the more your network is key** for more varied and often better opportunities. Early on in your career, your interview performance tends to determine which roles you can get. As you hit the senior levels, referrals from people you know can help increase your chances of getting a role that is a step-up for you. Beyond this level, people referring you is a more common way of being considered - and getting - senior+ roles. This people network can come from your personal network, but also from online professional networks like Twitter.

Advice for engineering managers to help their directs grow

What are ways you can support the career growth of engineers reporting to you? Below are a few approaches.

When at big tech:

- **Have career conversations earlier** rather than later. Promotions are a bigger deal in big tech than they are at smaller places, and the earlier you get on the same page with people on your team on where they are towards the next level, the fewer surprises you'll both have.
- **Prepare to have different career conversations** up to the senior engineering levels and ones after. Getting to the senior engineering level is a realistic path for every engineer, and as a manager, you should have the tools to support them. After this level, there might be no clear path - and even if there is, many people might not want to pursue it once they realize how the position changes. Take different approaches with these conversations.
- **Separate performance and promotions conversations.** Working hard, delivering outsized impact, and performing at the next level are often rewarded with promotions at smaller companies. This is rarely the case at big tech, where high performance is rewarded with bonuses and equity while performing at the next level is recognized with promotions. Assuming your company also works like this, set these expectations early.
- **Set realistic expectations for promotions.** Promotions are rarely a done deal at big tech, even if you, as a manager, are a strong supporter of a case. Avoid promises of promotions, and do your due diligence in getting feedback from others and calibrating your understanding of the promotion bar as you [prepare for people on your team to get promoted](#).
- **Avoid [promotion-driven development](#), where you can.** It can be tempting both for engineers and for managers to work on impactful but unnecessarily complex projects that can justify a promotion. My advice is to stop these efforts if you spot them. There should be plenty of impactful work that is challenging without needing to add unwanted complexity.
- **Promotions aside, help people grow** to become better engineers and team members. Promotions might or might not happen for reasons you cannot always

control. However, if people on your team become visibly better professionals while working on your team, you've done a fair job.

When at high-growth startups:

- **Healthy compensation and equity can be more important than promotions** at high-growth places during this growth phase. If engineers are [allocated fair equity](#), this equity value grows with the company. As this happens, promotions become less important while the growth lasts.
- **Spend less time on promotions** compared to big tech - but don't completely forget about them. As the company grows in size, you'll want to put career ladders in place and a lightweight promotion process.
- **Beware of overly rapid promotions** with an unstructured process. As tempting as it might be to keep recognizing high-impact work with a series of promotions, know that this will come back and bite you. This is how a graduate engineer can get promoted to Staff, then Head of Mobile in a span of two years - then struggle with the responsibility they were never ready for in the first place.
- **Consider the career options for the most senior engineer(s) at the company.** If you have one or two of the most senior or longest-tenured engineers at the company, it can be natural for them to inquire about when and how they'll get promoted. Get ahead of these questions and consider putting a career path in place - while also being aware of the dangers of promoting too fast. An approach can also be to make it clear that their level is terminal - at least for the time being - and their output is recognized through equity and bonuses.
- **Having too much focus on titles and levels early on is a culture smell** and might not be healthy for the startup. Titles and levels are naturally important at large companies - but impact, moving fast, and addressing business needs should come ahead of all of these while growing quickly. If you see the culture trend otherwise, try to get it back on track.
- **Going public introduces compensation tensions** after it happens, regardless of how the stock fares. When the stock goes down, it can cause retention problems unless stock refreshers are higher. When it goes up, it often raises complaints from people who think they should get higher equity refreshers. In either case, be

prepared to address concerns, work on a strategy to educate people on how public markets work, and put policies in place for public equity compensation and adjustments.

Your Path Will Be Your Own

It can be tempting to map your path years ahead, following some of the common - or not-so-common ones - described in this article.

However, just like every person is different, all career paths are unique. Common career paths are well-explored paths, especially in big tech, and ones where you can expect to find plenty of people who followed this path one way or the other. However, don't limit yourself to any of the ones described here.

The stronger your people network - both at work and outside of it - the more likely you'll come across interesting opportunities. These opportunities could help you move along the paths listed, and they can open doors to different and exciting ones.

What other advice do you have on how to think about career paths? Drop a comment below:

Thanks to [Andreas](#), [Karthik](#), [Nicky](#) and [Yohan](#) for their input and help with this article.



78 Likes

3 Comments



Write a comment...



Edmo Lima Writes Edmo's Logbook Nov 12, 2021

Great explanation Gergely!

So, A thing that is seen is some company has a role "Fellow Engineer" or anything. The truth is that I don't understand where the person is different from a Principal Engineer. Do you see anyone with this role or any explanation about this question in BigTechs?

♡ LIKE 💬 REPLY ...



Preslav Mihaylov Oct 30, 2021

Thanks for sharing this Gergely!

One thing which I feel like is missing is information about total comp between levels, how it changes on promos (which can help you evaluate wait for promo vs. leave for better opportunity), equity refreshers & how they're calculated.

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